

Oyster.com

The service aims to provide users with professional reviews of hotels from around the world

What's here?

This latest option Google Maps lets users find out more information about any location on the map

Industry Connect

of a fraud, the airline will definitely charge us. For a fraudster, it's simply about getting somebody's card or card details. I need the card number, the date and the CVV number and I can transact. So if you have these details, you can do a transaction. Now, Cleartrip has a dedicated fraud team. When a warning is raised, depending on the case, the transaction is cancelled. We have a fraud scoring from 1 to 10. Anything above 7 is definitely a fraud. In tricky cases, like say 5.1, there is a process of physical verification of calling and confirming that we follow. We see the person's response and judge.

What about building something for the mobile platform?

We had in fact launched a few things in the mobile platform as beta. Problem is that though it created a lot of search volumes and hype, nobody booked. Conversion is also important, right? Purely WAP applications too need network provider support. So they're no good. These days phones in any case are offering full browser experience. You can easily access the site from these phones. Only a few of the functionality attributes may not be available such as drop down suggestions, not being supported. Our initial design philosophy provided for access by almost everyone. For example, ours is a machine readable page.

We want to be the Google of the travel space. Anybody looking for any travel products should be able to get it through us. Whether it's bus, flight, rail, accommodation, anything. That is our end game.

Hearing aid applications can read out the page easily.

Apart from mobile, we even tried voice-based search. So you call a number and ask your query and the recognition software interprets it and reads out results (text to speech). We keep



With clear trip you can search and book through over 5500 domestic hotels and 1,09,000 international hotels, railway tickets, holiday packages, insurance and mobile services for travel and global destination guides

trying all sorts of these things to enhance our customers' experience and they are like our "labs" applications. Some flourish, some die their natural death. Innovation is important.

Your train calendar and graph utility is one such initiative?

Yes, absolutely. The air graphs, in fact, were used initially by most of our suppliers to weigh out their positions. We created the tool for suppliers, but adapted it to our customers. Train calendar was then adapted from that. When you're travelling by train, often you're fine travelling any date. You have a desired date and a

the API quickly and built our application around it. We have a symbiotic relationship with the railways though. They sell rail tickets through us while we supply them with hotels. Many of the hotels on IRCTC's web site are sourced through us.

Any other new initiatives?

Google is an open company. They support development greatly. We too love technology and supplement our data with Google products. We use the Google maps API to show locations of hotels. Our web site is end to end web 2.0. We use various platforms for development. For example, our trains platform runs on a platform called Ruby On Rails.

something known as Cleartrip videos, but we pulled it out eventually. These consisted of destination videos and we wanted to build a community around it. But the response wasn't that great, although, we did get some 1000-odd videos.

You're probably one of only few players in railway booking. Why should a customer book through you and not through the IRCTC web site? And what about the price difference?

There are several issues to consider here. At times, the IRCTC web site is working fine while their back end will not be working. Sometimes, it's the other way around; in which case we will do a lot of bookings. This is possible because their APIs and web site are on different systems. Again, there is the issue of branding. Some still feel that a ticket issued from IRCTC is an original, while that bought elsewhere is duplicate. As for price, we are allowed to take Rs. 10 per ticket that we book. Nobody minds Rs. 10 on a Rs. 300 ticket. Also, we provide a better user experience. Once you book a ticket and you want to act on it. Say you want to cancel it. It's much easier on our site. The way you search also is different. Some of these they 'borrowed' from us too. We have, for example, an all Mumbai search. This search will cover trains originating from VT, Borivli, Panvel and Thane. All of these are essentially Mumbai. This was a bit of innovation through human judgement. Multi-station boarding is also something we have. Sometimes a Mumbai-Delhi train is not available, but a Thane-Delhi train is. So people are OK with finding alternative modes of transport to Thane. We provide such kind of smart search on our web site.

week around that is OK with you. So with the calendar, you can just see visually which trains are available on what dates. Click on the suitable solution and just book. Instead of going day by day or searching for the next five days over and over again. The train calendar interfaces

It's a platform which we bet will be the next enterprise level platform to really hit it off. Many of our hotel applications are based on Java. Air products run on Lisp which is rarely used by people in India, or abroad for that matter. Again using Lisp as a back end, we're delivering a web 2.0 product. We have all our technology serviced in house. None of the development is outsourced, so we're able to integrate new products and platforms much quicker too. For instance, the API integration of IRCTC. Till the time the API released, much of the back end was already ready. Our product teams were busy understanding their system since long. We have tech development teams both in Mumbai and Bangalore. This makes our balance sheet stronger too. In-house technology and we love open source!

As far as user generated content we used to have